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***Queen Christina* and *Morocco*: Queer Liberation in Pre-Code Hollywood**

Pre-code Hollywood refers to the brief years between the implementation of sound in 1929 and the enforcement of the Production Code in July of 1934. The pre-code era is famous for its violent and raunchy films that are littered with sex, drugs, homosexuality and other taboo subjects that would be heavily restricted by the production code. The relative freedom of the pre-code era led to early depictions of queerness seen in films like *Morocco* (1930) and *Queen Christina* (1933). *Morocco* gives us arguably the most iconic on-screen kiss between two women when Amy Jolly, played by Marlene Dietrich, struts around in a tux and kisses a woman in a room full of people (fig. 1). A similar scene takes place in *Queen Christina* (1933). Greta Garbo, who plays the titular character, gives her lady in waiting Ebba a kiss and not a friendly peck on the cheek, but a proper romantic kiss (fig. 2). Both *Queen Christina* and *Morocco* display queerness in a way that wouldn't been seen again until the 1960's with the dissolving of the production code. The two films also play around with lesbian and crossdressing in similar ways but to different results.

The boldness and queerness of pre-code Hollywood did not happen by chance or in isolation. The 1920s, also referred to as the Roaring Twenties, saw huge social and cultural

changes. Fueled by the first wave of feminism the 19th amendment successfully passed giving women the right to vote. More women than ever before entered the workforce and participated in the growing economy. (Pruitt 2021). This movement towards the empowerment of women was seen in movies as female characters began to appear more prominently in leading and diverse roles.

At the same time the gay rights movement began to take shape in 1924 when “Henry Gerber, a German immigrant, founded in Chicago the Society for Human Rights, the first documented gay rights organization in the United States.” (History.com Editors 2017). Amidst the prohibition era was the so called “Pansy Craze” which was the surge in popularity of gay clubs and performers. At its height as many as 7,000 people were attending drag balls and gay clubs a level of visibility unprecedented in America at the time. Queer identities began to find expression not only in nightlife but also in mainstream media (Pruitt 2019). The Pansy Craze of the 20s exposed the straight community to gay community and in turn, “when sound film came in, urban audiences in particular were culturally primed for pansies, sissies, and lesbians.” (1999, 3).

However, the stock market crash of 1929 marked the end of the Roaring Twenties and it’s progressive nature. The Great Depression sent shockwaves through the American economy and shook the faith of the American people. A decade full of revelry, was now seen in a new light as “many believed that lax morality during the 1920s Jazz Age had been one cause of the Depression.” (Thompson, Bordwell, Smith 2022, 188). This, however, did not stop film companies from producing suggestive and raunchy films. On the contrast, film companies began to produce more provocative and suggestive movies to avoid financial ruin. This ultimately led to the MPPDA establishing what is referred to as either the Production Code or Hayes Code. While

pre-code films did not have to pass this code, there was an increase of scrutiny around films during the Depression era, and queerness still existed mostly in coded subtext. Pre-code era films like *Morocco* and *Queen Christina* were groundbreaking in how they push the boundary of gender norms and sexuality, but they were allowed to do so only in small ways. This is clearly seen as both films while starring openly queer actresses have stories that focus on a safe heterosexual relationship.

In *Morocco*, Marlene Dietrich's appearance as cabaret singer Amy Jolly leaves a lasting impression. The pivotal scene where Amy takes the stage in full men's drag—a sharply tailored tuxedo and top hat—captures not only the audience's attention within the film but also the attention of viewers for decades to come. This moment becomes Dietrich signature and is seen in her later movies such as *Blonde Venus* (fig. 3). She performs for a crowd of both men and women including her two male love interest. Despite the audience's initial reaction of boos and jeers, Dietrich's performance swiftly transforms the crowd's mood. The camera faithfully follows Amy as she sings, but it briefly cuts to different members of the audience as they watch her performance. The shots featuring Tom Brown played by Gary Cooper are at a high angle, so that we the audience are looking down at him. The perspective we are shown is Amy's point of view as she is higher up, being on stage, but it also works to emphasize the power Amy possesses at this moment. She is looking down on Tom Brown and he is looking up at her. As she walks on stage, she exudes a blend of masculine confidence and feminine allure. At the end of her song the crowd bursts into applause including Tom Brown.

One of the most memorable moments of the movie comes right after this as Amy still in drag kisses a woman in the audience. This is met with laughter and applause which further emphasizes Amy's charisma in this moment, but also the sad reoccurring patter of queerness

being depicted as something to laugh at. The laughter however does not take away the joy that many viewers felt when witnessing Marlene Dietrich small lesbian scene as Whatling's review of the *Celluloid Closet* point out in reference to *Morocco*, "these are moments remembered and recalled regardless of the hetero-textual resolution of the narrative" (Whatling 1997, 3). While *Morocco* has an overarching heteronormative story this one moment of lesbianism has lingered in cultural memory as an iconic instance of queer representation. At the heart of Amy Jolly's allure is her unique combination of seduction and masculinity. While the character may fit into the archetype of the classic femme fatale, her true power lies in her queerness. Her subversion of expectations and traditional gender roles make her so interesting to us the viewers and the audience she performs for in the movie. The same way that drag queens and gay performers drew in massive crowds of both straight and queer audiences in the height of the pansy craze. What makes this kiss so striking is the casual nature of the display. The kiss is not glossed over or hidden. The camera does not cut away as Amy kisses this woman, but remains faithfully fixated on her.

Marlene Dietrich's performance in *Morocco* is further enriched by the actress's own life. Dietrich was openly bisexual and often dressed in men's clothing. This personal element adds layers of complexity to her role as Amy Jolly. The kiss between the Amy and a random woman could be seen as a rare moment in which Dietrich's real-life struggle as a queer person was reflected on screen. In a time in which queerness was largely hidden Dietrich open bisexuality adds a layer of authenticity to a scene that at first glance seems like another example of films using lesbianism as a quick joke or as a way to appeal to men.

Dietrich's was not the only queer star of the talkie's era of Hollywood. She was part of the "Sewing Club" of Hollywood, which was not an actual club but a euphemism to refer to

Hollywood's underground sapphic community. This informal group of queer actresses and filmmakers includes Greta Garbo, Joan Crawford, Barbara Stanwyck and many others (Madsen 2015). Queer individuals have existed long before there was even a community, and Hollywood's attempt at hiding queer actors and writer is sadly just another example of queer individuals being forced into the closet.

In *Queen Christina*, director Rouben Mamoulian uses cinematography and mise-en-scene to subtly but powerfully convey the fluidity of gender and queerness in the character of Queen Christina. While actress Greta Garbo a Swedish-American actress who was openly bisexual brings this historic character to life (Britannica 2024). The film centers around Christina, a historical Swedish ruler known for her refusal to conform to traditional gender roles, her abdication of the throne and her refusal to marry. Also known famously or infamously for having romantic partners of both genders. From the opening of *Queen Christina*, it is clear that Christina will not easily fit into either gender role, but instead occupy the space in-between.

When Christina is being appointed as a child, she is given the role of "King" not Queen as the title of the movie suggests. This is both historically accurate and exemplifies how Christina flirts between masculinity femineity. Throughout the film Garbo's gives Christina an androgynous performance. She is often seen in masculine clothing and performing tasks typically associated with men such as hunting. After the coronation scene we jump forwards in time and in a long shot of two masculine figures riding horses. We follow one of them as they stride up the place steps arriving to a room full of men. It takes over a minute for this figure to face the camera and in a dramatic close up it is revealed that who we assumed to be a man was in fact our main character Queen Christina. The audience is not the only one that is confused at times of Christina's gender as Christina is mistaken for a boy by Antonio. She does not correct

this misunderstanding but seems to revel in it. That is until in a comedic manner the misunderstanding is revealed as the two are forced to share a room together and Christina must undress before him.

While Queen Chirstina's trait of cross dressing and her vehement refusal to marry is accurately portrayed in the movie, Garbo faced issues when she attempted to showcase Christina's lesbian tendencies. There is one kiss between Christina and Ebba despite there being clear historical proof of Christina's infatuation with her lady in waiting (Waters 1994). Even that is quickly backstepped as it is revealed that Ebba's is in love with and wishes to marry a man but is scared to ask for Christina's permission. The movie instead focused on the romance between Queen Christina and Spanish envoy Antonio, "which has no basis in history, Hollywood executives, like the Swedish patriarchs, seek to impose on their unconventional heroine a conventional romantic destiny." (Erkkila 1985, 13). As Christina falls for Antonio, she switches her attire from masculine clothing to more feminine dresses and jewelry supporting Lugowski claim that "During the Depression, such butch, powerful, cross-dressing, or simply intimate and affectionate women were often portrayed (and read) less as potentially lesbian than as shrews requiring taming." (Lugoski 1999, 16).

Garbo herself was not pleased with the resulting movie though it ended up being her most beloved performance. In a letter to friends, she vented her frustrations about the movie "just imagine Christina abdicating for the sake of a little Spaniard" (Waters 1994, 11). The remark highlights Garbo's frustration with Hollywood's ongoing homophobia and her disappointment in having to rewrite the movie to reflect heteronormative views rather than Queen Christina's or her own personal life as a defiant queer woman. Despite these personal misgivings, *Queen Christina*

was a significant step forwards for queerness in Hollywood and gave voice to a different lesbian character than Dietrich's cabaret seductress.

The ending of *Queen Christina* at first seems to be another tragic ending for a queer protagonist. Christina abdicated the throne to be with the one she loves but now her lover is dead so it feels as if she might have given up the throne for nothing. However, the last frame shows Christina looking stoically off the prow of the ship has resonated with viewers for decades (fig. 4). The scene represents not just sorrow but in a way liberation. All who see this scene can relate to the sadness but both queer and straight individuals can relate to feeling of relief that comes with taking your life into your own hands. As Christina sails away from her home she is also sailing away from the responsibility of the crown and the pressure to marry and produce an heir. Queen Christina lived for thirty more years after her abdication and while the movie ends here it is clear that her life did not. Garbo was directed by Mamoulian to think of nothing "I want your face to be a blank sheet of paper. I want the writing to be done by every member of the audience" (Erkkila 1985, 19). The storyline of being forced to leave home because people don't accept who you choose to love is a storyline that obviously resonates with the queer community, but like most movies in pre-code Hollywood the idea of queerness could only be implied indirectly. So once again the power of the story is left in the hands of the audience.

Queen Christina as well as *Morocco* both flirt with the idea of lesbianism, offering brief moments of queer liberation that pushed against boundaries of acceptable behavior in Hollywood. However, both these films ultimately centered around a heteronormative storyline expected by the film industry and the masses. Queer actors such as Marlene Dietrich and Greta Garbo who were as openly queer as the time period allowed, had to fight to convey even small, coded hints of their true selves. Although the Production Code in 1934 would soon forbid even

those portrayals of lesbianism, queerness would still stubbornly persist and the queer liberation movement in the 1960s would help dissolve the Production Code for good. The pre-code Hollywood era may have been short lived, but the movies of that era would be remembered for reflecting the shifting culture of the depression era and as proof of the resistance of the queer community.

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Figure 1



Figure 2



Figure 3



Figure 4